

BEATING ALL ODDS

Women representatives who have risen from the grassroots to get a seat at the national table



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

GENIBEN THAKOR, *48* ▶

| CONGRESS | *Banaskantha, Gujarat*

She may not be a giant-killer in terms of votes, but Geniben has single-handedly denied the BJP a hat-trick sweep in Gujarat. The only Congress candidate to have won here, she is said to have crowdfunded her campaign (raising Rs 50 lakh) while also putting in 18-hour workdays addressing bike rallies, *khatla parishad*s (door-to-door campaigns) and the smallest of gatherings. She reportedly also manned all the booths in her constituency on polling day. The effort paid off, as she defeated her BJP opponent Rekha Chaudhri, drawing support across her OBC cohort and some from even among the forward Chaudhris, the powerful dairy community. A grassroots worker, her first assembly poll run from Vav in 2012 ended in failure, but the never-say-die Thakor contested again in 2017 and this time defeated the BJP's dairy strongman Shankar Chaudhary. She replicated that success in 2022, and has moved from strength to strength since.



D.K. ARUNA, *64* ▶

| BJP | *Mahabubnagar, Telangana*

Her father and brother, both Congress leaders, were assassinated by Maoists in 2005. Aruna's husband and two of her in-laws have also been MLAs. Her own political journey began in 1996 when she contested from the Mahabubnagar LS seat, but she lost then. After some initial setbacks, she went on to become a two-term Congress MLA and a minister, before joining the saffron side in 2019. A veteran of padayatras and hunger strikes, she's been especially vocal about the irrigation water problems of the farmers in Mahabubnagar. Now she has become the first woman to be elected from here since 1952. Her defeat of Vamshi C. Reddy is even more laudatory as all the assembly segments in the constituency are with the Congress.

LATA WANKHEDE, *54* ▼

| BJP | *Sagar, MP*

Originally from Chhindwara, Lata came to Sagar after her marriage to local BJP leader and contractor Nandkishor Wankhede. Her first foray into politics was as a panch of Makroniya village in 1995, after which she was elected sarpanch (2010-15). Now she has travelled a lot further, trouncing the Congress's Chandra Bhusan Bundela by a big margin. Wankhede is from the Kurmi community, has been the president of the state BJP mahila morcha in the past and led several agitations on women's issues.



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